Discord:

A Parent's Plain-English Guide

Discord started as a chat app for gamers. Today it is used by millions of young people for gaming, homework, hobbies and friendship groups. It is real-time, invite-based and built around communities called servers — which can be amazing, but also risky. This guide explains how it works, what the dangers are, and how to keep your child safer.

150M+ Monthly active users globally

13+ Minimum age to sign up

FREE Parental controls via Family Centre

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01 WHAT IS DISCORD?

Discord is a communication platform built around servers — online communities where people text, voice call and video chat. It is used for gaming, schools, study groups, hobbies and friendships.

Servers — Communities organised by topics. Anyone can create a server and invite others to join.

Channels — Servers are split into text and voice channels for different topics and conversations.

Voice & Video — Users can voice call or video chat in real time. Screen sharing is also available.

Direct Messages — Private one-to-one or group chats outside of servers. Strangers can message your child.

Roles & Permissions — Server owners can give roles that unlock access to certain channels and features.

Rots & Integrations — Third-party tools can add extra features — some are helpful, some are not.

Discord is invite-based by default. Most harm happens when a child joins a server they don't know well, or talks to someone they've never met in real life.



KNOW THE REALITY

Anyone can create a Discord account with no age verification. Any child can enter any date of birth. Many adults pretending to be teens are on Discord.

Trust and community are built in — which is why it can be such a positive space, but also how some people exploit that trust to harm children.

THE PLATFORM PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **Invitation is the key** — Your child can join almost any server using an invite link. These links can be shared anywhere — games, YouTube, TikTok, friends.
2. **Real-time, always on** — Conversations happen in real time. Once something is said or seen, it can be screenshot, saved and shared elsewhere.
3. **Anonymity is easy** — Usernames and custom avatars make it easy for people to hide who they really are.

BY THE NUMBERS

150M+ monthly active users globally — Discord is huge — and still growing.

Any age can sign up — No age verification. Only self-reported dates of birth.

Harm happens in servers — Most reports to safety teams involve contact from strangers in servers, not just DMs.

02 SAFETY SETTINGS THAT HELP

Discord has a range of built-in protections. Many are on by default — but some need to be checked.

Explicit Content Filter — Scans and blocks explicit images in DMs. On by default for all users.

DM Safety Settings — Limits who can message your child. Set to "Friends" by default. Keep it that way.

Server Privacy — Servers are private by default. Your child must accept an invite to join from someone.

Safe Direct Messaging — Automatically scans DMs for harmful links and sends safety warnings.

Report & Block — Easy reporting and blocking tools. Reports go to Discord's safety team 24/7.

Quiet Hours — Mute notifications at certain times to reduce distractions and support better sleep.

These tools are helpful, but no setting replaces your involvement and conversations.

03 SETTING UP FAMILY CENTRE

Family Centre lets you connect your account with your teen's account so you can manage settings, see activity and get insights.

1. **Go to Settings** — On your child's account, click the gear icon (User Settings).
2. **Open Family Centre** — Select "Family Centre" from the menu.
3. **Invite Your Teen** — Follow the steps to send an invite link to your teen.
4. **They Accept** — Your teen needs to accept the invite on their account.
5. **You're Connected** — Once connected, you can manage settings and see activity.

WHAT YOU CAN MANAGE (THROUGH FAMILY CENTRE)

Account Settings — Manage privacy settings, DM rules, friend requests and more.

Weekly Activity Report — See how much time they spend on Discord and who they message most.

Screen Time Limits — Set daily time limits and downtime (such as homework or bedtime).

Content & Privacy — Adjust content filter level and privacy options.

04 THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

Stranger contact — Adults can join servers and befriend children.

Grooming and manipulation — Offenders build trust in servers then move chats to DMs or other apps.

Explicit content — Servers can contain violence, hate, self-harm or sexual content.

Scams and phishing — Fake links, giveaways and "nitro" scams are common in servers.

Oversharing — Location, school, routines and personal info shared in chats can be dangerous.

05 THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION



- Ask open questions: "What servers are you in?" "What do you like about Discord?"
- Talk about trust: "Not everyone is who they say they are online."
- Explain what to do if something feels wrong.
- Agree on time limits and downtime.
- Remind them they can always come to you.

The "10-minute chat"

Sit down with your child and ask them to show you how they use Discord, focusing on understanding their world rather than judging it.

Childline support: If you or a child you know needs support, Childline is available 24/7 at 0800 1111 or childline.org.uk.

06 WHAT TO DO IF THINGS GO WRONG

Stay calm and take screenshots — Save evidence of the content, messages or profile.

Report on Discord — Use the in-app report tool. Choose the right category and include details.

Report and seek help — Contact CEOP (ceop.police.uk) or Childline for support. For serious concerns, contact police.